The Job-Seeker's Guide to Microsoft Word

How To Create Your Own Resume With Microsoft Word

Kalana Amarasekara

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Dedication

I dedicate this manual to anybody who is looking to write a resume, whether for a job application, college application or just to develop your professional portfolio. Organizing and presenting your qualifications on one page can be a daunting task, and I hope you can get as much helpful information out of this manual as possible.

Acknowledgments

I would like to thank my instructor, Dr. Janine Solberg, for her guidance and support throughout my writing process. Taking Dr. Solberg's class and using the strategies on accessibility I learned in class while writing this manual has taught me how to write something that is visually and verbally accessible to all Microsoft Word users alike. I hope I can continue honing my ability to write material aimed at varied external audiences.

During our class workshops this semester, I received substantial feedback from my classmates on how I could improve the writing quality, design and accessibility of my manual. Their feedback has been integral in helping me create my manual, and I would like to thank them for their help.

I would like to thank Daniel Frank, the Editor-In-Chief of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian, for his input while I was conducting my user experience research. Understanding what various people use Microsoft Word for gave me a broader understanding of its functions as a whole, and helped me develop guidelines for people who may want to use these functions. I would also like to thank Daniel Estrin, the Head Opinion Editor of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian, and Chris Chan, my classmate in Dr. Solberg's class, for agreeing to take part in my usability testing exercise. I was able to determine how effective the instructions I had written in the manual were in helping users find what they needed to.

Finally, I would like to thank the staff at Staples Print & Marketing Services, Hadley, for printing the physical copy of the manual for me and making it accessible beyond digital platforms.

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Introduction

Creating a resume often entails distributing your professional information, including your academic and work credentials, on a document of a certain size. Sometimes, formatting your document to contain all of your professional information can prove challenging, especially if you want your resume to look not just presentable, but also impactful, on a job application.

Fortunately, you can use Microsoft Word's various formatting tools to design a resume that you feel captures your best qualifications well and makes a positive impression on a potential hiring manager. This manual has three sections explaining various steps you can take whilst creating your resume.

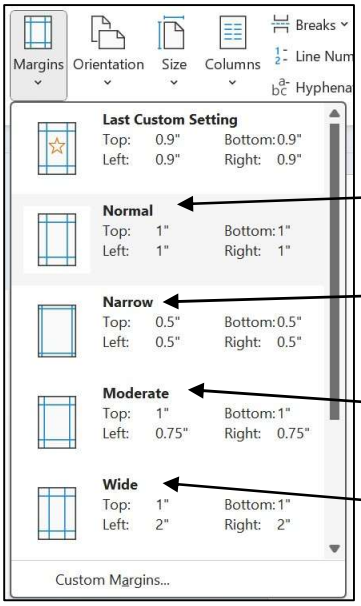
The first section, **Designing and Formatting Your Resume**, explains how you can adjust the physical features of your resume - margins, text alignment, bulleted lists and page colors – to your satisfaction, so you feel that it presents well. The second, **Composing Your Resume**, focuses on how you can use Microsoft Word's various fonts and font styles to draw attention to different parts of your resume, and also ensure that it is well-written grammatically and mechanically. The third, **Sharing Your Resume**, explains how you can print a document either digitally or physically so you can present it to an interviewer.

Section 1
Designing and formatting your resume

1.1 Adjusting page margins with the Margins tool

You might want to adjust the margins of your resume or cover letter to either distribute text more effectively or make more space for a higher amount of text.

1. Navigate to the **Layout** menu, then select the **Margins** tool on the far left.
2. Select the margins setting of your choice.



The **Normal** margin leaves a margin of **1 inch** from each side of the page

The **Narrow** margin leaves a margin of **0.5 inches** from each side of the page

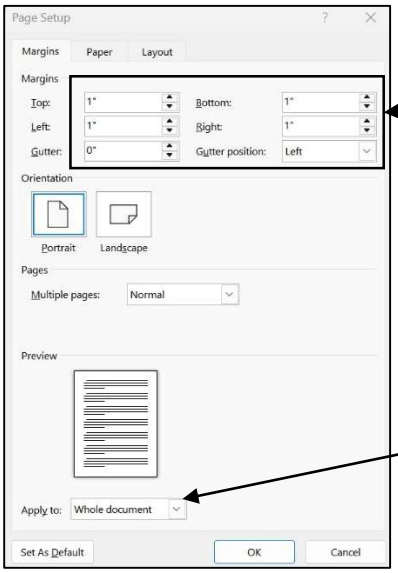
The **Moderate** margin leaves a margin of **1”** from the top and bottom of the page, and **0.75”** from the left and right of the page

The **Wide** margin leaves a margin of **1”** from the top and bottom of the page, and **2”** from the left and right of the page

If you want to distribute more information throughout the page from top to bottom, you can use the **Moderate** margins.

If you want to distribute more information throughout the page from top to bottom and left to right, you can use the **Narrow** margins.

3. To create custom margins, select the **Custom Margins…** option at the bottom of the drop-down menu and enter the **Top**, **Bottom**, **Left** and **Right** margins of your choice.



To distribute the information on your resume evenly, professional advisors recommend that you keep the **Top** and **Bottom** margins to **1”**

To keep the formatting throughout a resume with more than one page, you can use the **Apply to:** feature and apply it throughout the document

4. Once you have entered your margin values, select **OK**.

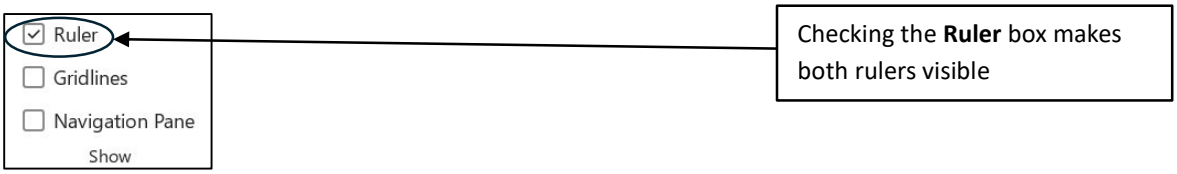
If you want to use a margin other than the **Normal**, **Narrow**, **Moderate** and **Wide** margins, you can select a **Custom Margin** by entering the margin values of your choice.

You may want to use **Custom Margins** if you feel that you cannot distribute the information in your resume effectively using the **Normal**, **Narrow**, **Moderate** and **Wide** margins.

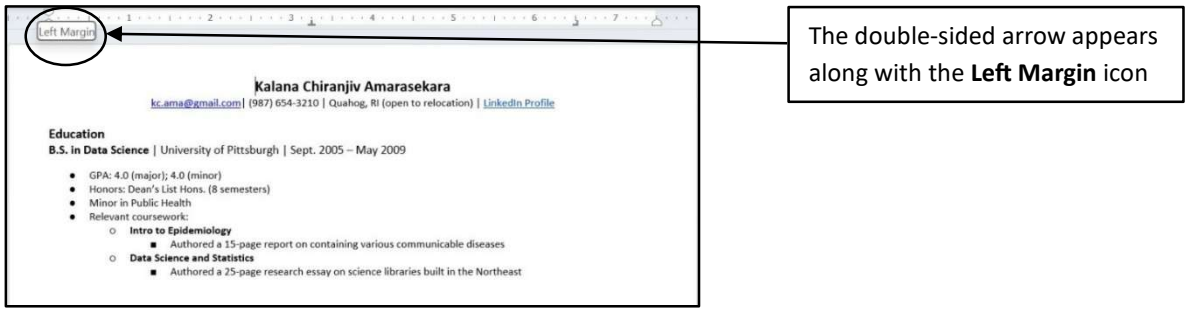
1.2 Adjusting page margins with the Ruler tool

If you want to adjust your page margins manually, you can do so with the **Ruler** tool.

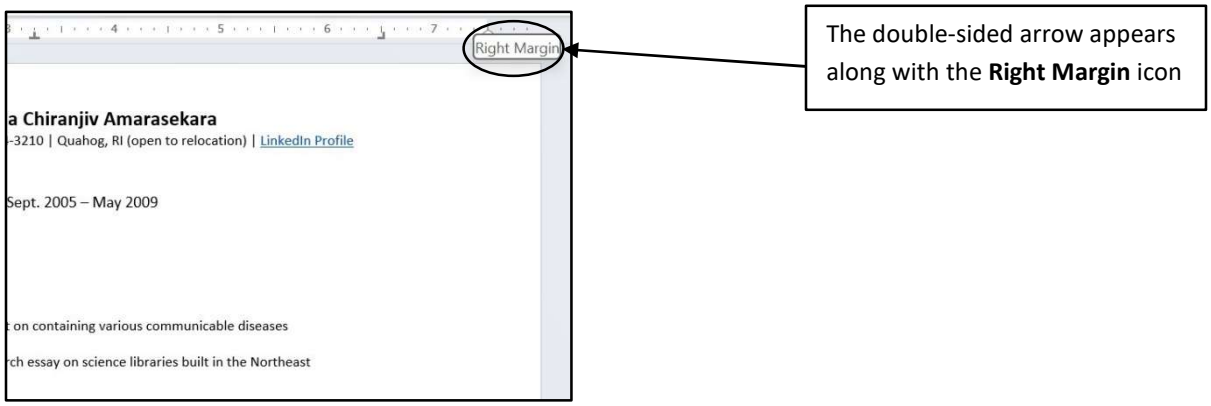
1. Navigate to the **View** menu and check the **Ruler** box to make both the vertical and horizontal rulers visible.



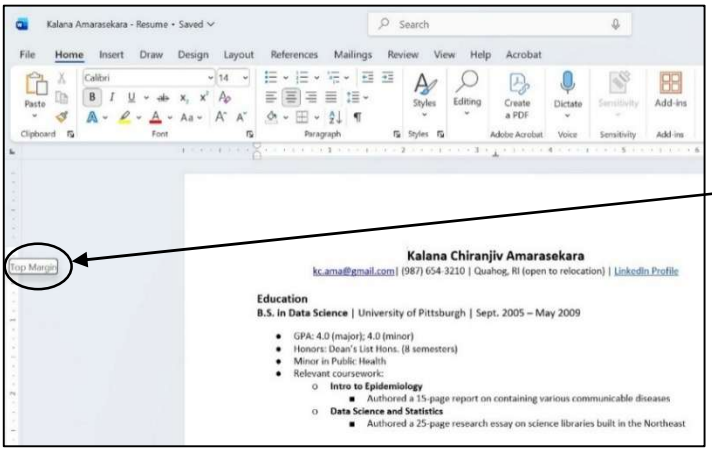
2. To adjust the left-hand margin on the page:
   a. Navigate to the left-hand side of the horizontal ruler, where the cursor turns into a double-sided arrow (↔) and the icon **Left Margin** appears.
   b. Drag the arrow to change the margin.



3. To adjust the right-hand margin on the page:
   a. Navigate to the right-hand side of the ruler, where the cursor turns into a double-sided arrow (↔) and the icon **Right Margin** appears.
   b. Drag the arrow to change the margin.

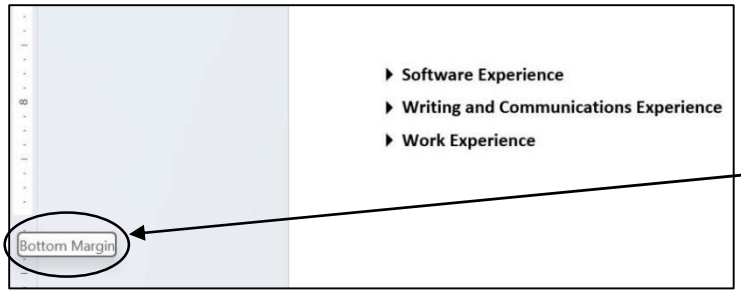


4. To adjust the top margin on the page:
    a. Navigate to the top of the vertical ruler, where the cursor turns into a double-headed arrow (↕).
    b. Drag the arrow to change the margin.



The double-sided arrow appears along with the **Top Margin** icon

5. To adjust the bottom margin on the page:
    a. Navigate to the top of the vertical ruler, where the cursor turns into a double-headed arrow (↕).
    b. Drag the arrow to change the margin.



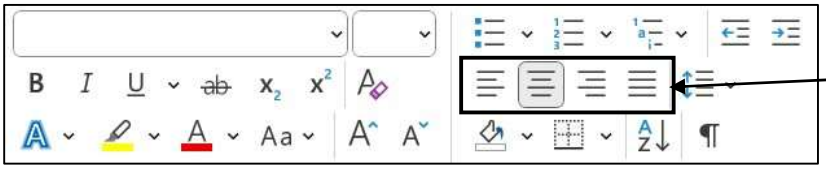
The double-sided arrow appears along with the **Bottom Margin** icon

1.3 Aligning text

While it is good practice to align most of the text on your resume and your cover letter to the left, you may want to center the header of your *resume* to ensure a hiring manager can read it.

1. Select the text in your header.

2. To center *the text*:
   a. Navigate to the **Home** menu, then select the **Center** button.



From left to right:
the **Align Left** button,
the **Center** button,
the **Align Right** button
and the **Justify** button

   The text appears as such:

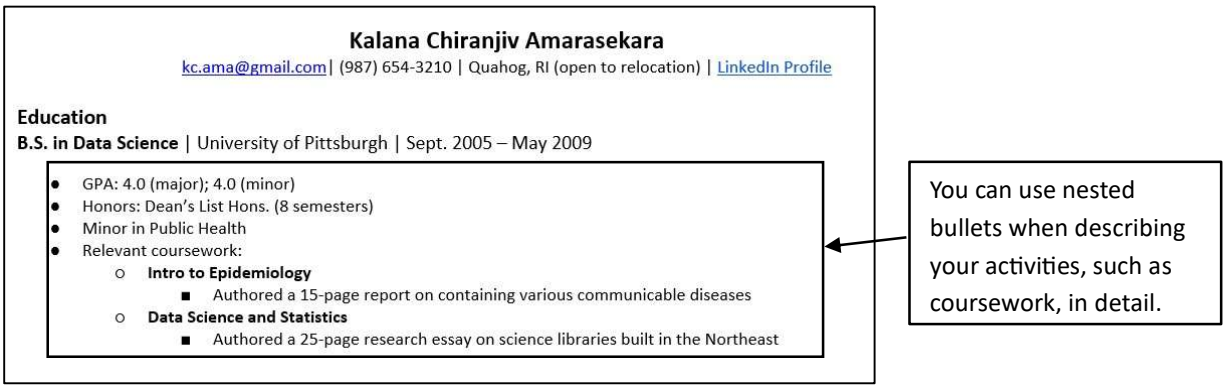
3. To align the text to the right:
   a. Navigate to the **Home** menu, then select the **Align Right** button.
   The text appears as such:

If you are including an image of yourself in your heading, you may want to align the text to the right to make space for the image.

1.4 Creating a bulleted list with nested bullets

You can use bullet points on your resume to list your professional qualifications, educational qualifications and achievements. You can also use nested bullets to list several subpoints underneath one major point.

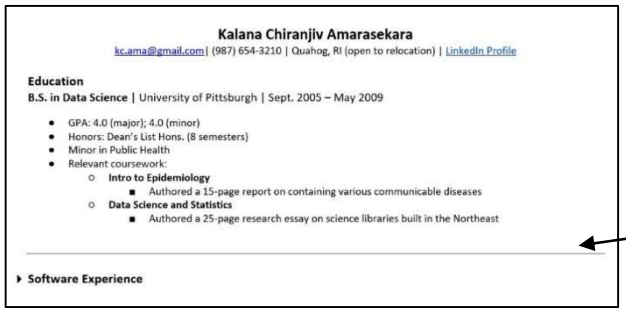
1. Select a place on the document where you type your first list item, then navigate to the **Home** menu and select the **Bullets** option.
2. After typing your first sentence, press the **Enter** key to move onto your second sentence.
3. To create nested bullets, press the **Enter** key, then press the **Tab** key.
4. To end the list, press the **Enter** key twice.



1.5 Inserting a horizontal line

You can use horizontal lines to separate your resume into sections and make it more readable.

1. To insert a horizontal line using your keyboard:
    a. Insert your cursor into a new line of text.
    b. Enter three dashes on your keyboard, then press the **Enter** key.

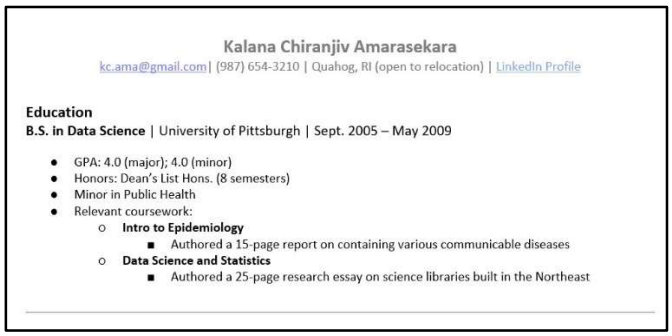


Using a horizontal line between your sections can make it clearer to distinguish between them, as there is more space

2. To insert a horizontal line using the **Borders** tab:
    a. Navigate to the **Home** menu and select the **Borders** option.

When you select the **Borders** option, it presents a drop-down menu

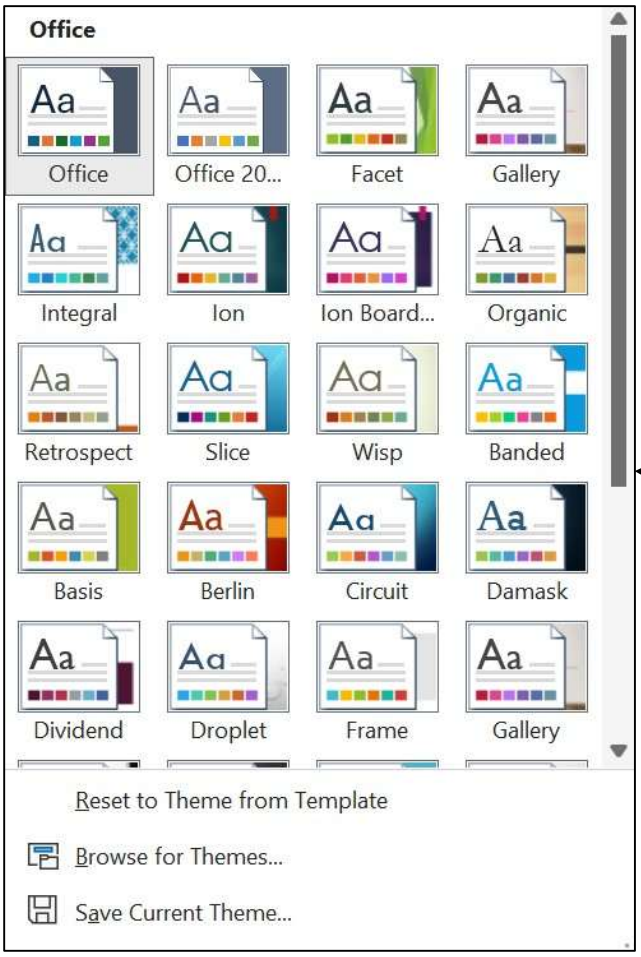
    b. Select the **Horizontal Line** border.



1.6 Creating and using different themes

You can select a theme for your resume by using the **Themes** menu. Usually, changing the document's theme means changing the color of the pages and the text, as well as changing the font.

1. Navigate to the **Design** menu.
2. Select the **Themes** menu on the far left.
3. Select a theme of your choice.



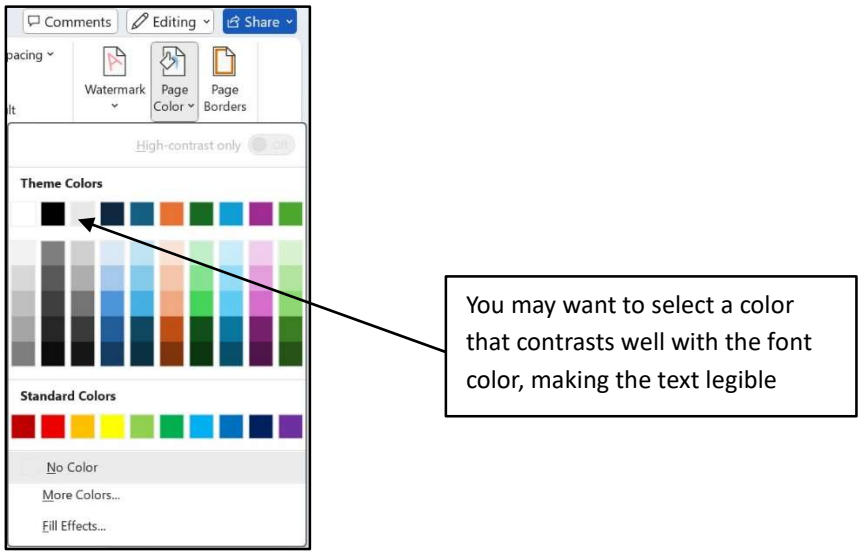
You can scroll down the menu to view further themes

You may want to select a theme with a legible font and a neutral background color to maintain a balance between professionalism and aesthetic appeal.

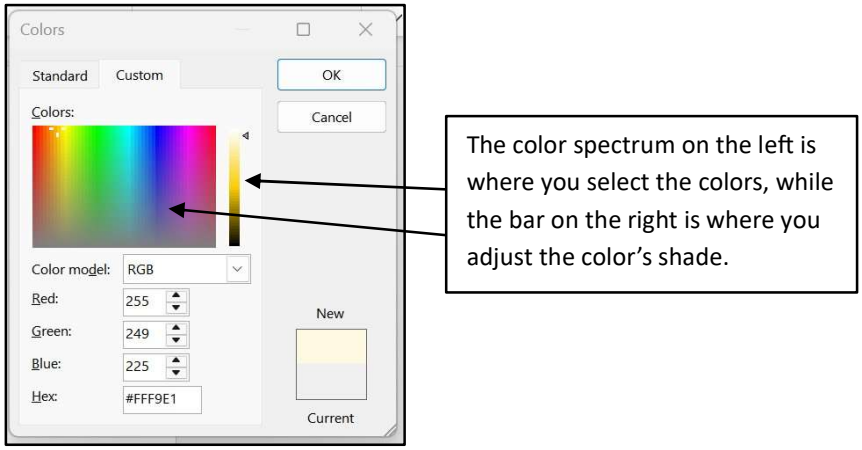
1.7 Changing the page color

To change the background color of your resume without having to change your theme, you can use the **Page Color** feature, which offers a variety of colors for your page.

1. Navigate to the **Design** menu.
2. Select the **Page Color** menu, which is the second from the right.
3. To select a Theme color:
    a. Go to **Theme Colors**.
    b. Select a color of your choice.



4. To select a custom color:
    a. Select the **More Colors…** button.
    b. Select the **Custom** button.
    c. Select any color on the color spectrum, and adjust its shade.



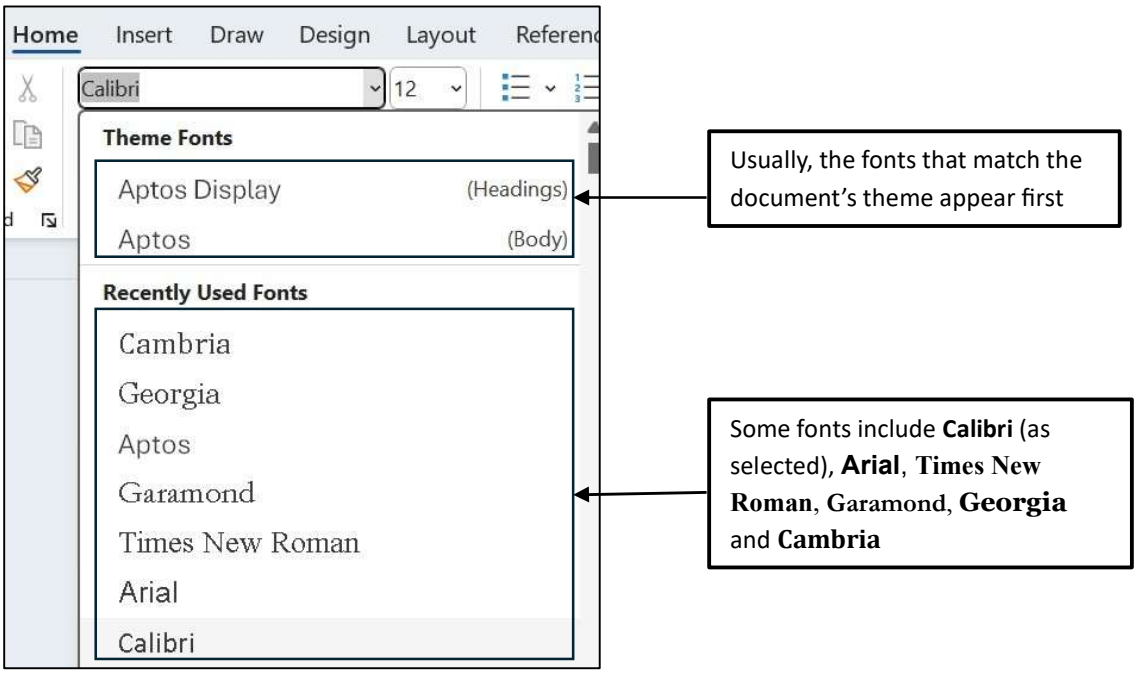
    d. Once you have selected your color, select **OK**.

Section 2
Writing your resume

2.1 Selecting different fonts and font styles

You can select a font for your resume and your cover letter. Career advisers recommend that you use a font that is legible to hiring managers and ATS systems, which may not be able to read some fonts easily.

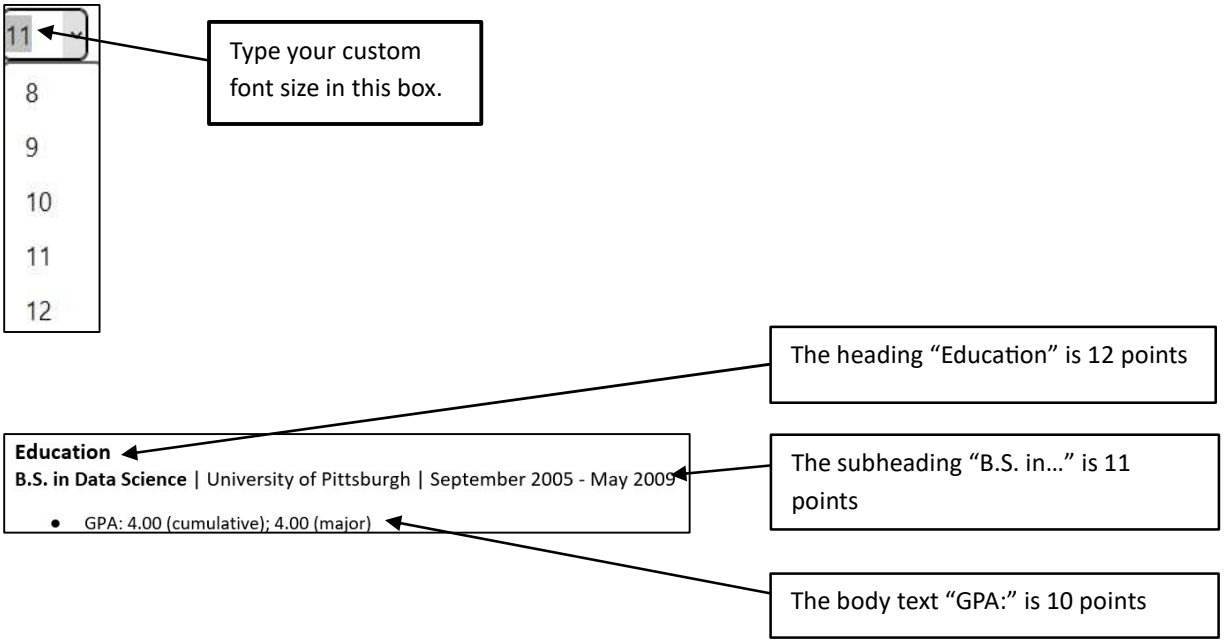
1. Navigate to the **Home** menu.
2. Select the **Font** box to view the list of fonts.
3. Select a font of your choice.



2.2 Adjusting font size

When writing both your cover letter and your resume, you can use the **Font Size** box to adjust the size of your text.

1. Select the piece of text whose size you want to adjust.
2. Navigate to the **Home** menu.
3. Locate the **Font Size** box and select a font size from the drop-down menu. Alternatively, you can type in a custom font size.

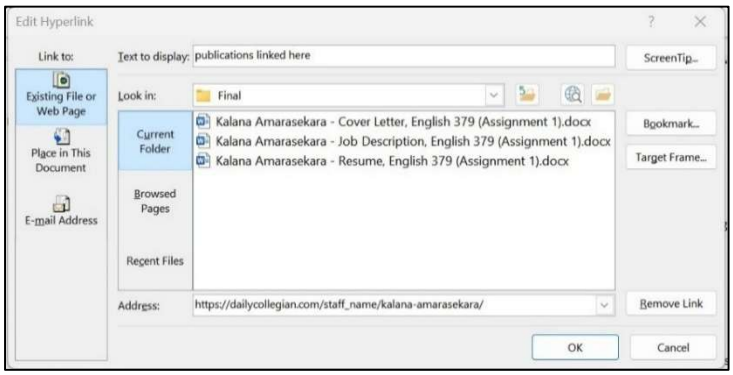


Font sizes in the drop-down menu span from 8 to 72 points. Headings can typically be less than 20 points, while for body text can be between 12 and 10 points. Subheadings can be anywhere in between 10 and 20 points.

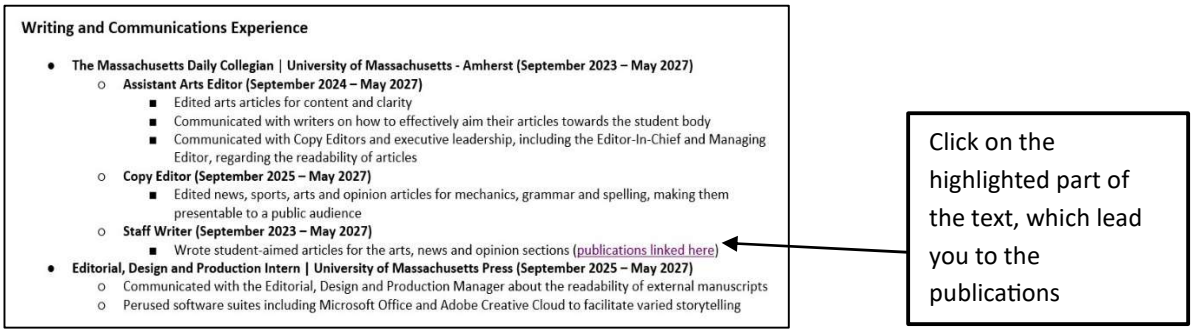
2.3 Inserting a hyperlink

When you create a resume, you usually have to include hyperlinks to some parts of the text. Such parts include your e-mail address, your LinkedIn profile, and your online portfolios if you have any. You can use the **Link** feature to insert hyperlinks onto your resume.

1. Copy the URL you want to link onto your clipboard.
2. Select the piece of text you want to hyperlink.
3. Click on the **Insert** tab at the top of the screen and select **Link**.
4. To insert a hyperlink to a URL:
    a. Select the **Existing File or Web Page** option on the **Link** pop-up.



    b. Paste the URL into the **Address** box.
    The text you have selected ("publications linked here") appears with a hyperlink to the URL:

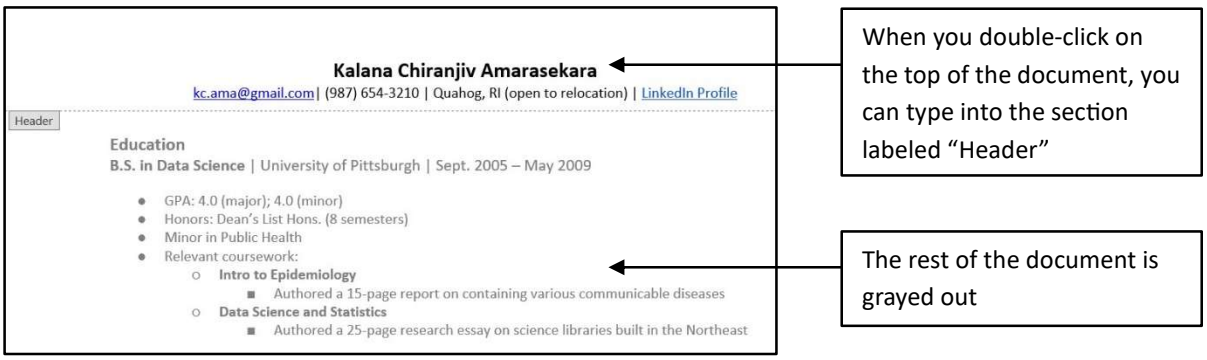


5. To insert a hyperlink to your E-mail address:
    a. Select the **E-mail Address** option on the **Link** pop-up.
    b. Paste your E-mail address into the **Address** box.
    Your E-mail address appears with the hyperlink to the address:

2.4 Inserting a header

You might want to add a header to your resume to save space for its body. A header is also a good place to include your name and contact information so it is immediately visible to a potential hiring manager.

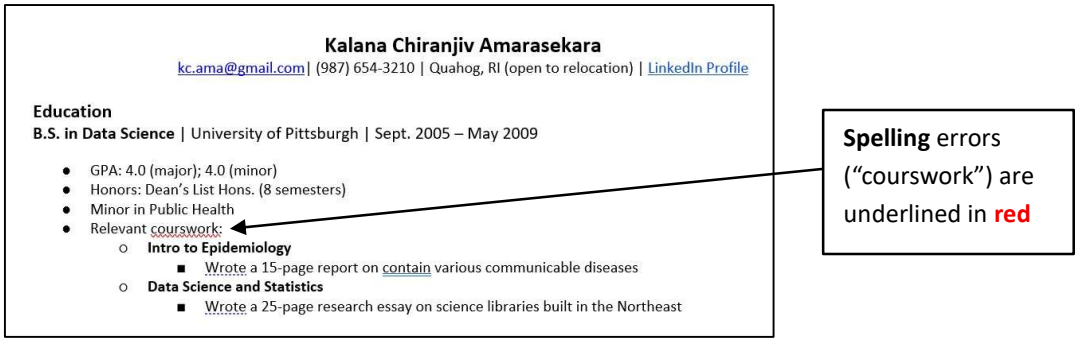
1. Click on the top of your Word document twice. You can then type in the section labeled "header."
   The remainder of the document is grayed out, meaning you cannot type in it.



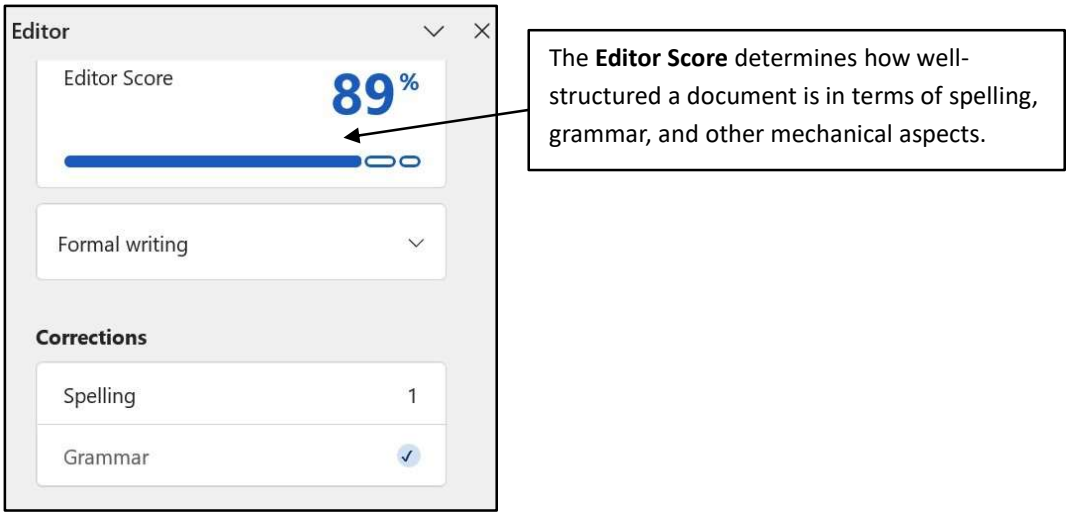
2. Type the text of your choice into the header.

2.5 Using the Editor tool for spelling

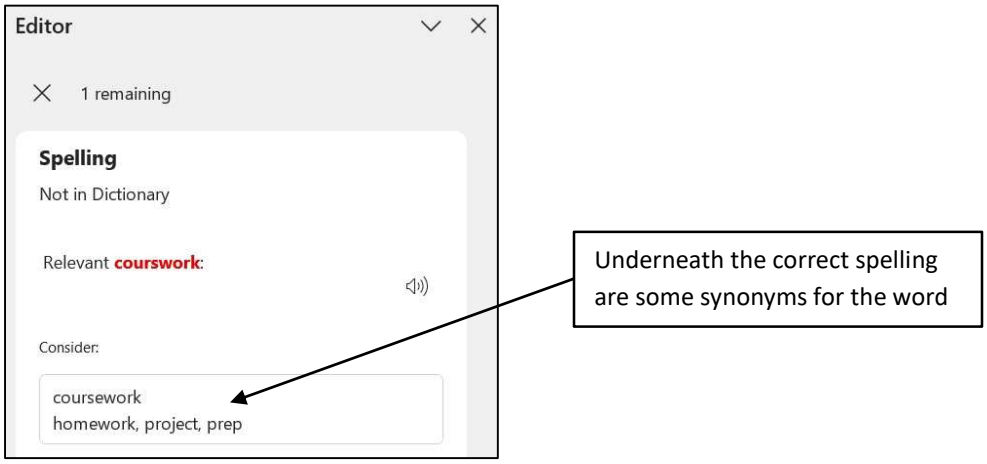
The Editor tool is useful for you to review the mechanics of your writing, including your spelling, as you aim to make your resume or cover letter as well-written as possible.



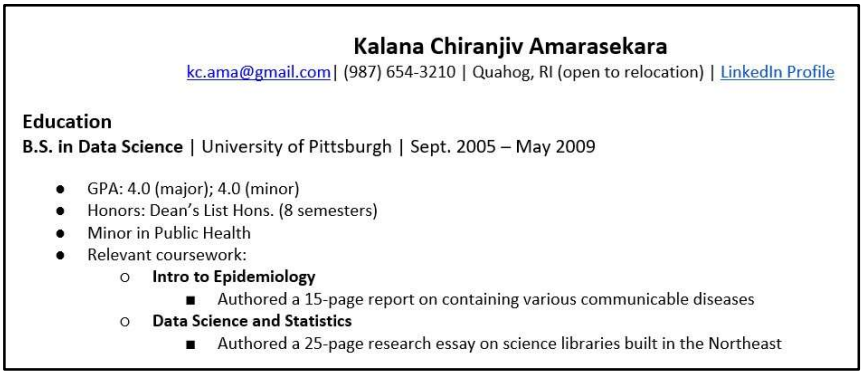
1. Navigate to the **Home** menu, then select the **Editor** button.



2. To edit for spelling, select the **Spelling** option, then select the button underneath the **Consider** tab.
   The corrected spelling appears.



After you have selected the correct spelling, the underline below the word disappears.



Kalana Chiranjiv Amarasekara
kc.ama@gmail.com| (987) 654-3210 | Quahog, RI (open to relocation) | LinkedIn Profile

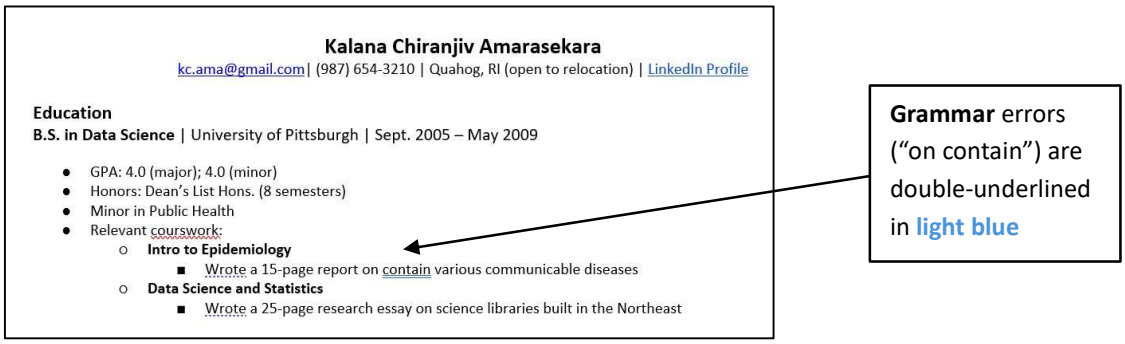
Education
B.S. in Data Science | University of Pittsburgh | Sept. 2005 – May 2009

- GPA: 4.0 (major); 4.0 (minor)
- Honors: Dean's List Hons. (8 semesters)
- Minor in Public Health
- Relevant coursework:
  - **Intro to Epidemiology**
    - Authored a 15-page report on containing various communicable diseases
  - **Data Science and Statistics**
    - Authored a 25-page research essay on science libraries built in the Northeast

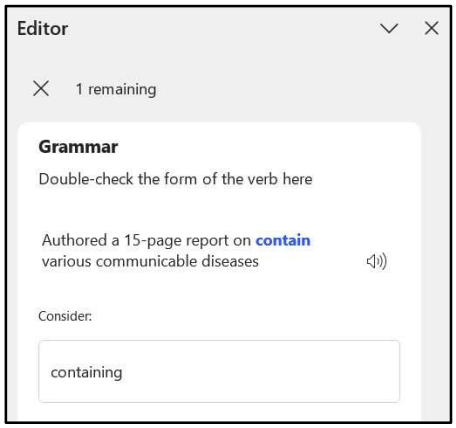
Most of the time, you will use the **Editor** tool to proofread your document and edit it for mechanics, rather than for content. You yourself can edit your documents for content, as you have the best idea of what you want to write!

2.6 Using the Editor tool for grammar

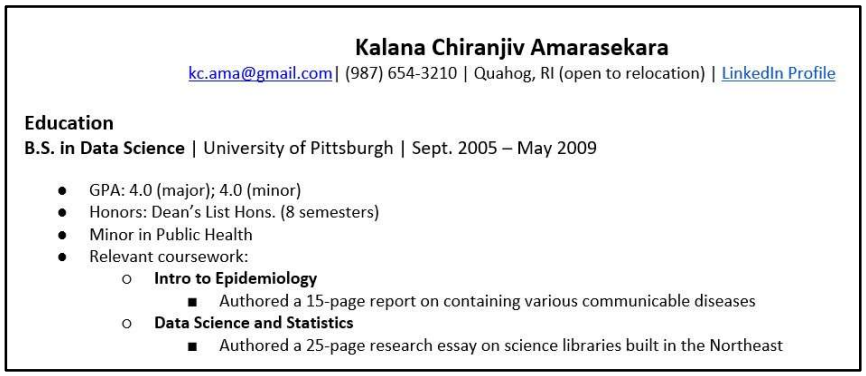
You can also use the Editor tool to make sure your resume is grammatically correct.



1. Navigate to the **Home** menu, then select the **Editor** button.
2. To edit for grammar, select the **Grammar** option, then select the button under the **Consider** tab.
   The corrected grammatical term appears.



After you have selected the correct grammatical form of the word, the underline below the word disappears.

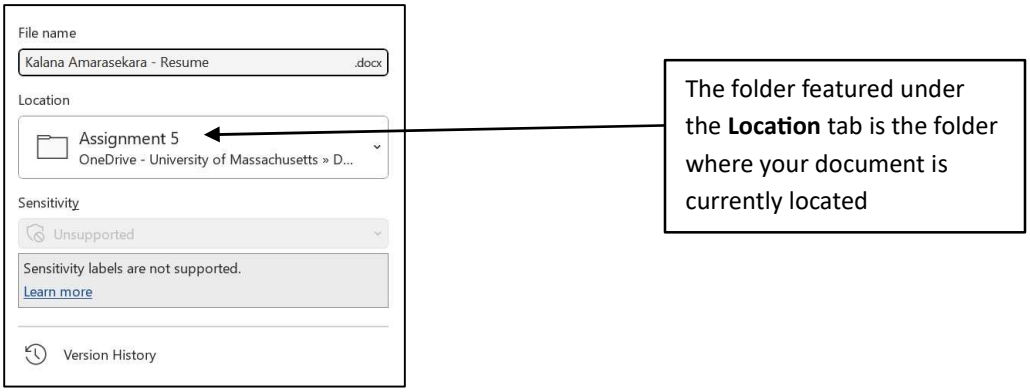


Section 3
Sharing your resume

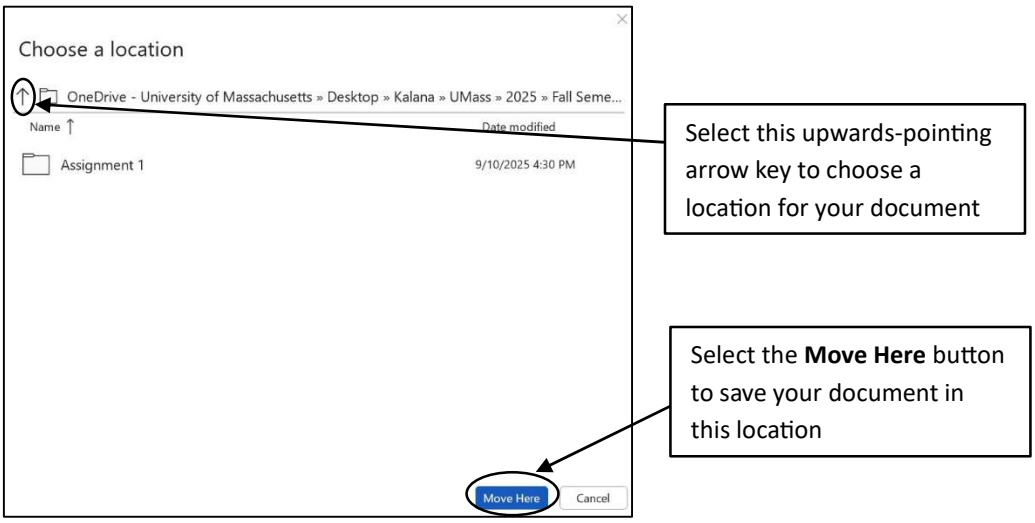
3.1 Saving a Word document

You can save your resume in a folder of your choice, especially if you want to place it in a location where you can find it easily.

1. If you are using a PC, press **Ctrl+S** to save the document; if you are using a Mac, press **Command+S** to save the document.
2. To select the location you want to save your document in, select the file name of the document and select the **Location** option from the drop-down menu.



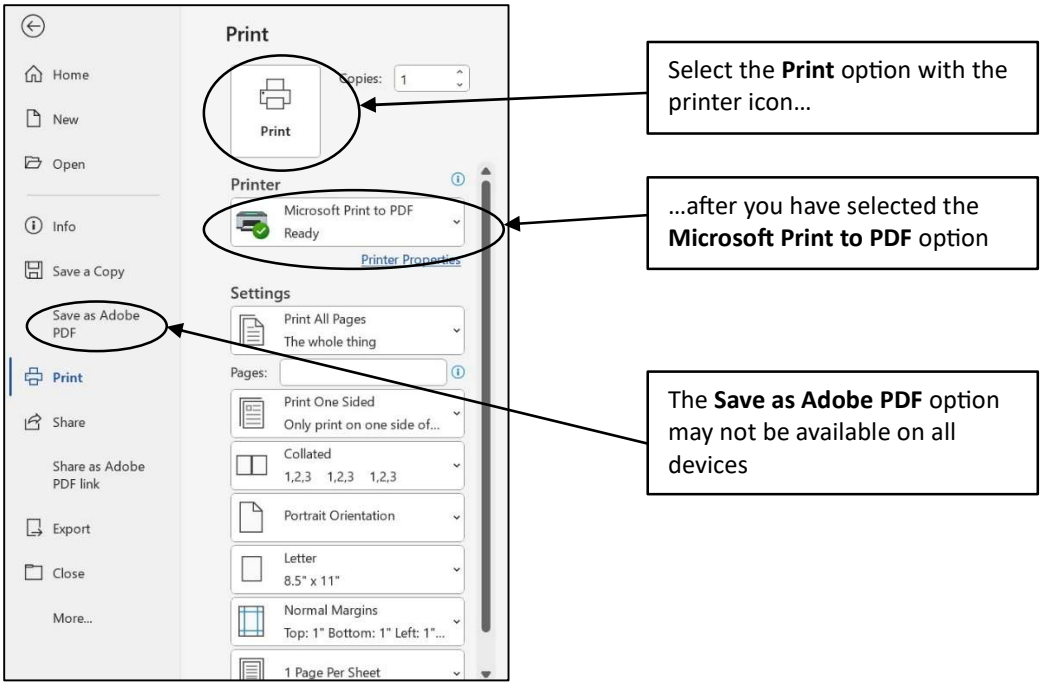
3. Select the upwards-pointing arrow key to choose a location for your document; it gives you a selection of folders to place the document in.
4. Once you have found a folder, select it, then select the **Move Here** button.



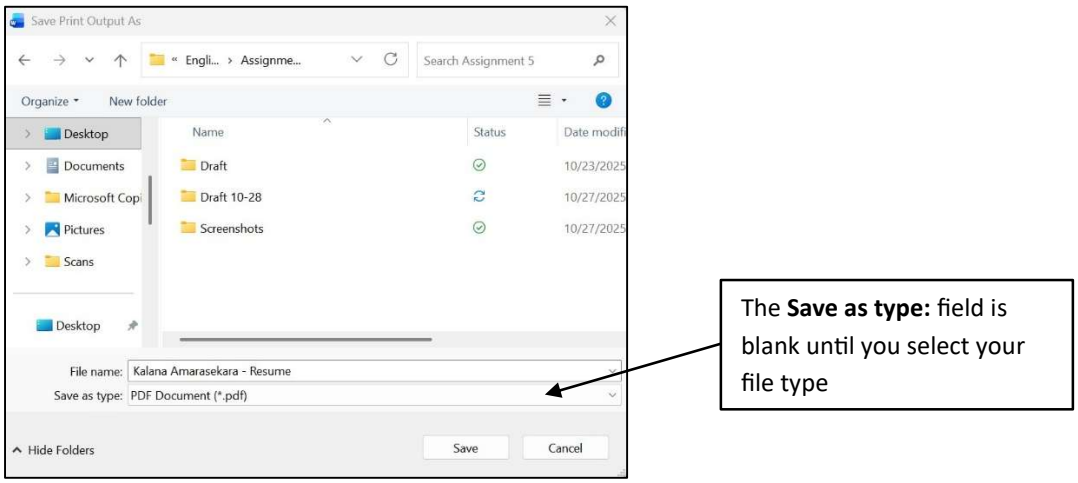
3.2 Saving a Word Document as a PDF

Saving a Word Document as a PDF can be useful because some employers might ask you to send your cover letter and resume to them in PDF format.

1. Navigate to the **File** menu.
2. Select the **Print** option on the left-hand menu.
3. Under **Printer**, select the **Microsoft Print to PDF** option.
4. Select the **Print** option with the printer icon.



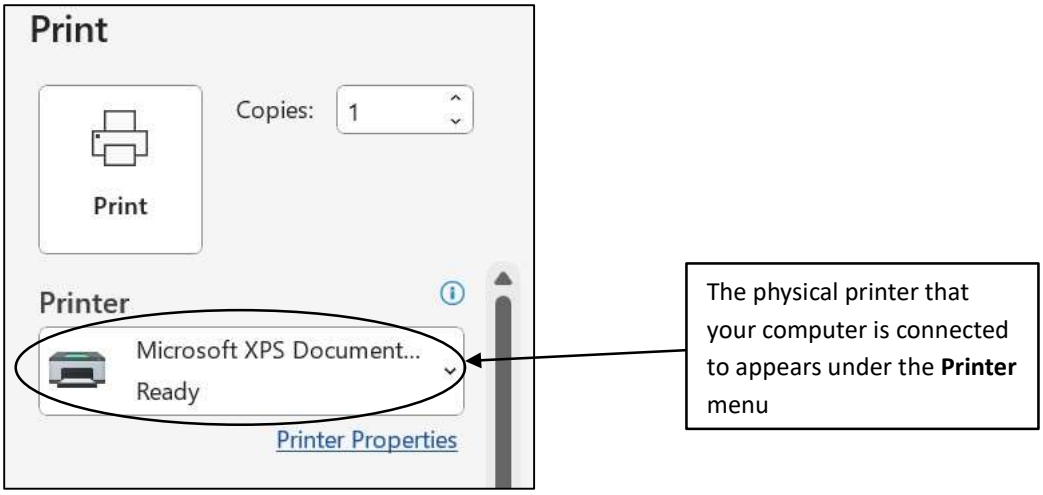
5. Once you have printed the file as a PDF, select a folder where you want to save it.
6. Enter a file name of your choice into the **File name:** field.



3.3 Printing your resume

You may want to physically print your resume if you must submit a hard copy of it as part of your application. It is also good practice to keep a hard copy of your resume for your personal records.

1. Navigate to the **File** menu.
2. Select the **Print** option on the left-hand menu.
3. Select the printer that your computer is connected to, then select the Print button.



This manual was written and designed with the use of Microsoft Word.

The screenshots for the modules were obtained through the use of Snipping Tool.

The cover image was obtained through Canva Stock Images.

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